

Hypertrophy

12-Week Mesocycle

Flagship · Intermediate · Gym · 5 days per week

- Push · Pull · Legs · Upper · Lower split
- Renaissance Periodization volume landmarks (MEV → MAV → MRV)
- Two programmed deload weeks (Week 5 and Week 9)
- Linear and double progression, governed by Rate of Perceived Exertion

Program Overview

GOAL	Add 6 to 10 pounds of lean mass over 12 weeks with less than 2% bodyfat gain. Balanced physique — no specialization.
WHO IT IS FOR	Intermediate lifter with at least one year of consistent training. Full gym access. Five sessions per week of about 70 minutes. Eating in a 200 to 400 calorie surplus.
WHO IT IS NOT FOR	Beginners (use Beginner Gym 12-Week). Anyone in a fat loss phase (use Fat Loss 12-Week). Anyone with fewer than four training days per week available.
EQUIPMENT	Full commercial gym — barbell, dumbbells, bench, squat rack, cable station, leg press, hack squat or pendulum, lat pulldown, leg curl machine, hip thrust pad.
SPLIT	Push / Pull / Legs / Upper / Lower across five days. Every muscle group is trained twice per week. Saturday and Sunday are rest days.
PERIODIZATION	Template Tier 1 — 12-week linear hypertrophy mesocycle with programmed deloads at Week 5 and Week 9.

Weekly Volume Curve

Hard sets per muscle per week. Volume landmarks follow Renaissance Periodization: **Minimum Effective** is the floor that drives growth, **Maximum Adaptive** is the productive range, **Maximum Recoverable** is the ceiling you can recover from. Deload weeks are shaded.

Week	Phase	Chest	Back	Quads	Hamstrings	Side Delts	Biceps	Triceps	Glutes	RPE
1	Minimum Effective	10	12	10	8	10	8	8	8	7
2	Building	12	14	12	10	12	10	10	10	7
3	Building	14	16	14	12	14	12	12	12	8
4	Maximum Adaptive	16	18	16	12	16	14	14	14	8
5	Deload	8	9	8	6	8	6	6	7	6
6	Building	16	20	16	14	18	14	14	14	8
7	Building	18	22	18	16	20	16	16	16	8.5

Week	Phase	Chest	Back	Quads	Hamstrings	Side Delts	Biceps	Triceps	Glutes	RPE
8	Maximum Recoverable	20	24	18	16	22	18	18	16	9
9	Deload	10	12	9	8	10	8	8	8	6
10	Intensification	14	16	14	12	14	12	12	12	9
11	Intensification	12	14	12	10	12	10	10	10	9
12	Peak / Photos	8	10	8	6	8	6	6	6	7

Week 1 · Foundation

Rate of Perceived Exertion is capped at 7 across every working set — leave three reps in reserve. This week is about grooving movement patterns and entering the mesocycle fresh, not chasing weight on the bar.

Day 1 — Push · Chest, Shoulders, Triceps · 70 minutes

Warm-up: 5 minutes easy bike · band pull-aparts 2 sets of 15 · band shoulder dislocates 2 sets of 10 · empty-bar bench press 2 sets of 8.

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Load	Rest	RPE	Notes
1	Barbell Bench Press	3 × 6–8	RPE 7	3 min	7	Pause one second on chest each rep.
2	Incline Dumbbell Press	3 × 8–10	RPE 7	2 min	7	30-degree bench. Neutral grip is fine.
3	Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press	3 × 8–10	RPE 7	2 min	7	Stop at forehead. Do not lock out.
4	Cable Lateral Raise	3 × 12–15	RPE 8	75 sec	8	Lean away. Lead with the elbow.
5	Cable Triceps Pushdown	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	75 sec	8	Rope attachment. Full lockout.
6	Overhead Dumbbell Triceps Extension	2 × 10–12	RPE 8	60 sec	8	Single dumbbell, two hands.

Cool-down: doorway pec stretch 30 seconds per side for two rounds · child's pose 60 seconds.

Day 2 — Pull · Back, Rear Delts, Biceps · 70 minutes

Warm-up: 5 minutes easy row · scapular pull-ups 2 sets of 8 · band face pulls 2 sets of 15.

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Load	Rest	RPE	Notes
1	Weighted Pull-up (or Lat Pulldown)	3 × 6–8	RPE 7	3 min	7	Full hang at bottom. Chin clears the bar.
2	Barbell Row (Pendlay or T-Bar)	3 × 8–10	RPE 7	2 min	7	Pull to lower sternum.
3	Chest-Supported Dumbbell Row	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	2 min	8	Elbow path at 45 degrees.
4	Cable Face Pull	3 × 12–15	RPE 8	75 sec	8	High elbows. External rotation.
5	Incline Dumbbell Curl	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	75 sec	8	Full stretch at the bottom.
6	Hammer Curl	2 × 10–12	RPE 8	60 sec	8	Slow two-second eccentric.

Day 3 — Legs (Quad Bias) · 75 minutes

Warm-up: 5 minutes easy bike · hip circles · leg swings · bodyweight squats 2 sets of 10 · empty-bar back squat 2 sets of 5.

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Load	Rest	RPE	Notes
1	Barbell Back Squat	4 × 6–8	RPE 7	3 min	7	Hit depth. Brace hard.
2	Romanian Deadlift	3 × 8–10	RPE 7	2 min	7	Push hips back. Neutral spine.
3	Leg Press (high foot position)	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	2 min	8	Knees track over toes.
4	Walking Dumbbell Lunge	2 × 10 per leg	RPE 8	90 sec	8	Long stride. Front knee tracks forward.
5	Seated Leg Curl	3 × 12–15	RPE 8	75 sec	8	Squeeze at the top. Two-second eccentric.
6	Standing Calf Raise	3 × 12–15	RPE 8	60 sec	8	Full stretch. One-second pause at bottom.

Day 4 — Upper Body · 65 minutes

Warm-up: 5 minutes easy row · band pull-aparts · empty-bar overhead press 2 sets of 8.

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Load	Rest	RPE	Notes
1	Overhead Press (Barbell or Dumbbell)	4 × 6–8	RPE 7	3 min	7	Glutes tight. No leg drive.
2	Weighted Dip (or Dip Machine)	3 × 8–10	RPE 8	2 min	8	Lean forward for chest. Upright for triceps.
3	Cable Row (mid-grip)	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	2 min	8	Pull to belly button.
4	Lat Pulldown (wide pronated)	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	90 sec	8	Drive elbows down. Do not lean back.
5	Dumbbell Lateral Raise	3 × 12–15	RPE 8	60 sec	8	Slight forward lean. No swing.
6	EZ-Bar Curl	2 × 10–12	RPE 8	60 sec	8	Strict. No hip thrust.
7	Skull Crusher (EZ-Bar)	2 × 10–12	RPE 8	60 sec	8	Bar to forehead. Elbows locked.

Day 5 — Lower Body (Posterior Bias) · 75 minutes

Warm-up: 5 minutes easy bike · hip circles · glute bridges 2 sets of 10 · empty-bar Romanian deadlift 2 sets of 5.

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Load	Rest	RPE	Notes
1	Barbell Hip Thrust	4 × 8–10	RPE 7	2 min	7	Pause one second at top. Chin tucked.
2	Conventional Deadlift	3 × 5	RPE 7	3 min	7	Reset each rep. Form before load.
3	Bulgarian Split Squat	3 × 8 per leg	RPE 8	2 min	8	Long stance. Slight forward lean.
4	Hack Squat (or Pendulum Squat)	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	2 min	8	Full depth. Controlled eccentric.
5	Lying Leg Curl	3 × 10–12	RPE 8	75 sec	8	Hard squeeze. Two-second eccentric.
6	Seated Calf Raise	3 × 15–20	RPE 9	60 sec	9	Push hard. Burn through it.

Days 6 and 7 — Rest

Active recovery only. 30 to 60 minutes of walking, mobility work, sauna if available. No training, no sprints, no "just one set." Recovery is when adaptation happens.

Progression Rules · Weeks 2 through 12

Double Progression on Accessories

Hit the top of the rep range on every set. Next session, add weight and drop back to the bottom of the range.

Linear Progression on Main Lifts

Bench, squat, overhead press, deadlift, and hip thrust. Add 2.5 kilograms to upper body lifts and 5 kilograms to lower body lifts each week, until reps drop or Rate of Perceived Exertion overshoots the cap. Then hold the load and add a set.

Weekly Volume Additions

Through accumulation phases, add one set per major muscle each Monday. The new set goes on the second session of that muscle group, on an isolation movement — never the heavy compound.

RPE Progression

Weeks 1 to 3 capped at 7. Week 4 capped at 8. Weeks 6 to 8 capped at 8 to 9. Weeks 10 to 11 capped at 9. Week 12 capped at 7 for the peak and photo week.

Deload Weeks 5 and 9

Same exercises, same days. Working sets cut in half. RPE capped at 6. No reps-to-failure work. Non-negotiable — this is where supercompensation happens.

Stalled for Two Weeks

Drop the load by 10 percent and rebuild. Do not grind through plateaus.

Why This Works

The Push / Pull / Legs / Upper / Lower split trains every muscle twice per week — the frequency sweet spot for hypertrophy according to Schoenfeld's 2016 meta-analysis. The volume curve (Minimum Effective → Maximum Adaptive → Maximum Recoverable → deload → intensification) is the Renaissance Periodization mesocycle model: accumulate fatigue progressively, then dissipate it, exposing the supercompensated adaptation underneath.

Week 12 is intentionally low volume so the work actually becomes visible. Most lifters end mesocycles flat, fatigued, and bloated. This one ends sharp.

The two deload weeks are non-negotiable. They are not rest weeks — they are tissue recovery weeks that let connective tissue catch up to muscular adaptation. Skipping them is the single most common reason lifters stall on hypertrophy mesocycles.

Expected Results

If you hit at least 85 percent of sessions, eat in a controlled surplus, and sleep at least seven hours per night:

- Six to ten pounds of scale weight gain — roughly 70 to 80 percent of which is lean mass.
- Bench press up 5 to 10 kilograms. Back squat up 10 to 15 kilograms. Deadlift up 10 to 20 kilograms.
- Visible growth in the arms and shoulders by Week 8.
- Visible growth in the chest and back by Week 12.
- Photos at the end of Week 12 will look meaningfully different from photos taken in Week 1.

Evidence

Every prescription in this program is anchored to peer-reviewed research or evidence-based coaching resources.

Schoenfeld 2017	Dose-response relationship between training volume and hypertrophy.	pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/27433992
Schoenfeld 2016	Training frequency meta-analysis — volume-matched.	pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/27102172
Helms et al. 2016	Rate of Perceived Exertion in resistance training prescription.	pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/27328853
Renaissance Periodization	Volume landmarks — Minimum Effective, Maximum Adaptive, Maximum Recoverable.	renaissanceperiodization.com
Grgic et al. 2018	Effects of rest interval length on hypertrophy.	pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28933059

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